protection of Indian cities and installations from Chinese air attack, he also raised the possibility of US fighter aircraft assisting the Indian Air Force “in air battles with the Chinese air force over Indian areas.” In addition, Nehru also requested the loan of two squadrons of bombers, which would be manned and serviced by Indian personnel trained in the United States.[65]

While US assistance became unnecessary after China declared a ceasefire within two days of Nehru’s appeal, the combination of defence inadequacies, the time required to build them up, and the fear of a renewed Chinese attack in the interim led India to accept the US–UK offer of an air defence agreement in July 1963. For their part, the United States and United Kingdom, after much wrangling over their respective responsibilities and commitments in assisting India in the event of a renewed Chinese attack, settled on this mode of military assistance because of multiple imperatives: deterring China without getting into a shooting war with it (the latter being mainly a British concern triggered by Hong Kong’s vulnerability), drawing India closer to the West, and preventing its excessive rearmament, thus at the same time reassuring and retaining Pakistan as an ally.[66] Under the terms of the agreement, the United States undertook to install six permanent radar installations and train Indian personnel in their operation as well as to join the United Kingdom in conducting peacetime training exercises with the Indian Air Force for improving the effectiveness of India’s air defence.[67] Accordingly, the first exercise was conducted in the Delhi and Calcutta areas in November 1963 with the participation of one Royal Air Force fighter squadron and one US Air Force fighter squadron, with two Australian bombers serving as “mock Chinese targets.” But this enterprise was discontinued soon thereafter, with Nehru denying permission for a second exercise scheduled for April 1964 because of domestic opposition, lessening of